Standing on the Roof Naked

By Francess Lantz

I don't know why . . . I wanted to be a boy until I was thirteen years old. To this day, I still feel more comfortable in baggy boy clothes than dresses. My hair is short and tangled and in my eyes instead of long and silky like some Pantene commercial. I'm different. And in this world, let me tell you, different is not good.

INTRODUCTION

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It's Monday morning and I'm at school. Walking alone, as usual.

"Hey, Johnny," Rory Peterson calls as I walk past. Actually, my name is Jeannie, but the jocks who like to harass me think it's a hoot to call me John.

"Nothing wrong with her that a hot date wouldn't cure," Mike Forelli says.

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"Yeah, right-a hot date with a hot dyke," Rory snickers.

At home Mom greets me at the door with a smile and a plate of peanut butter cookies. "The doctor came by today." I freeze. The cookie feels like it's coming up in my throat. "Daddy ate a little more today. Dr. Heidleman was pleased."

I let out a breath and will my shoulders to relax. My father hasn't been taken to the hospital. He isn't dead. He's got cancer. But Mom never uses the C word. "He's under the weather," she says. Or, "He's feeling poorly."

He's dying! I want to scream.

I'm mad all the time-at Rory Peterson and his brain-dead buddies, at my father for getting sick, at myself for being such a freak.

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At lunch on Fridays we're allowed to play CDs in the cafeteria. Different kids take turns acting as DJ. Today I come into the cafeteria and see a kid

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setting up a couple of turntables. I've seen him around before, but I don't know his name. He's over six feet tall and skinny, with pale skin and spiky black hair. He reminds me of a spider, but not a dangerous one. A daddy longlegs maybe.

He sets up a microphone and starts to spin a stack of record albums. It's all old soul music, really funky stuff. . He's really putting on a show. I notice a few jocks are whispering and snickering. They can't deal with anything new or different. Their motto is: If it's unusual, it must be ridiculed. Who is this dude? When the bell rings, I walk past the turntables. "Hey, Reilly," someone calls. He looks up. Now I know his name.

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Last week I saw a book in Borders called *Lesbian Couples*. Some of the women in it looked like me-skinny and flat-chested, with short hair and no makeup.

Is that what I am? I wonder. A lesbian?

I try to imagine kissing a girl. Strange. I try

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to imagine kissing a boy. Also strange. What's wrong with me?

When I was six, I started drawing pictures of car wrecks and plane crashes. Lots of blood, lots of severed body parts. All I knew was that when I drew those pictures, I felt wild, I felt free. Like standing on the roof naked, screaming my lungs out.

Now it's music that does that for me. I wish I had the talent to get up in front of everybody. I wish I had the nerve.

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Mom has started sleeping in the La-Z-Boy recliner in the spare bedroom. That must mean my father is getting worse. I peeked in at him yesterday morning. His cheeks were covered with stubble and his hair was mussed. And his body under the covers, it looked so small, more like a child's than a man's. He didn't see me. He was staring at the wall, at nothing.

Each time my mother gets up out of the La-Z-Boy, I hold my breath. If I can hold it until she

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sits back down, my father won't die. I wrap my arms around my legs and go on waiting.

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"Jeannie, do you know Reilly Briggs?" Mrs. Filbert asks. "He's the boy who was playing records in the cafeteria last week. He's in my third-period class. He told me he's looking for someone to write raps to his beats. I gave him your name," she says. "I hope that's all right."

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It's study hall and I get a pass to go to the restroom. Oh, shit. Rory Petersen and Mike Forelli are hanging out in the hall near the water fountain. I do an about-face, but it's too late. They see me. "Hey, Johnny, need to use the boys' room?" Rory calls, coming in close to leer at me.

Mike sidles up behind me, cutting off my path of escape. "Do you think she pees standing up?" he muses.

"Maybe *she* is actually a *he*," Rory announces. "I mean, what if old Johnny isn't a girl who wants to

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be a guy, but a guy who wants to be a girl?" Mike nods. "We could find out."

They look at each other. Then suddenly they grab me. "Hey!" I try to break free, but they've got my arms pinned to my sides and they're half-dragging, half-shoving me into the boys' room. I let out a shriek, but it's too late. I'm inside, watching the door thump closed.

"Please," I whimper. I'm a pathetic sight. Frightened, humiliated, my knees weak and shaking. "Let me go."

"Not till we see what you got down there," Rory says. He reaches for the snap on my jeans and pops it open. Suddenly, the door opens and, like a spider in shining armor, Reilly Briggs walks in.

"What the hell's going on?" Reilly asks, glancing nervously at me.

Mike grabs my jeans and pulls them down. I'm too mortified to speak, to move. I'm just hunched over and shivering.

"Let her go or I'm going straight to the

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principal," Reilly says.

"Oh, for Christ's sake," Rory groans. "What does it matter what's in John-John's pants? Male *or* female, I don't want to get near it." Mike laughs. They exchange a glance, then release me and walk out the door, roughly shoving Reilly against the wall as they go.

I pull up my pants and fumble with the zipper. "You're Jeannie Holtz, right?" He smiles. There's definitely a rap in all this."

I don't write raps, don't have a clue where to start. Still, all day long, words, phrases, even some rhymes begin to percolate in my head. I don't know where they're coming from.

Am I a girl, a boy, a lesbo, a fag?

I don't want a label, I don't need your tag.

I say the lines over and over in my head.

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[A few days later I go to Reilly's. He] lives in an apartment house near the river. "Ms. Filbert says you're a poet," Reilly tells me, clearing aside

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some records to sit on the bed.

"I don't know how to rap," I say. "But I wrote down a couple of lines."

My hand is trembling as I pull the paper from my pocket. It drops on the floor and Reilly snatches it. I stand there, cheeks burning, stomach churning. I want to run away and never look back. Finally, he turns around, looks me over. He taps the page and smiles. "I think I can do something with this."

Soon I'm spending almost every afternoon at Reilly's house. Mom doesn't ask where I am. She's too busy taking care of my father to even notice I'm gone.

Reilly puts beats behind my rhymes. He makes me read them into the microphone, over and over. He doesn't laugh at me, thank God, and he never mentions what he saw that day in the boys' room. All he says is:

"Don't just read the words, Jeannie, *feel* them. Get pissed."

I shake my head and stare at the pattern on

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his Indian bedspread. I can write mad, but I can't let myself *be* mad. It's too scary.

"I'll lay down a beat," he says. "Just close your eyes and sing. Don't think, just do it. Whatever pops into your head."

But the only words that come are too painful to say. *I'm a freak, I'm a freak, I'm a freak.*

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[My] father passed away late last night. I can't take in the fact that my father is dead. It's like the Grand Canyon, too vast to comprehend. I want to cry and scream and fall on my knees, but my feet are paralyzed and I'm unable to produce even one tear.

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The winter dance is this weekend. Reilly is going to be there, spinning discs.

I let Mom take me to the store, buy me a dress I'd never pick for myself in a million years. It's black velvet with lacy snowflakes around the neck and sleeves. At home I try on the dress and

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shoes. Mom looks really pleased. I force myself to smile, to push my hair out of my eyes. It's the least I can do for her.

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It's the night of the dance and I'm standing outside the school in my new dress and shoes. Underneath, just to make me feel more comfortable, I'm wearing black bike shorts and a sleeveless black undershirt. I can hear the music pounding inside, hear the people talking and laughing.

I practically run into Mike Forelli.

"Whoa, look at Johnny," he tells his buddies. "Shake it, baby, shake it. Show us what you've got!" Everyone laughs. I snake my way through the crowd of writhing bodies on the dance floor, putting some distance between Mike and me. Nobody notices me. I close my eyes and let the music throb through me. I pretend I'm alone in my room. Finally the music ends and Reilly starts setting up his turntables, a tape deck, and a mike.

He told me at our second rehearsal that he

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wanted me to perform my rap tonight, but I said no. I knew I couldn't get up in front of the entire school and rap. Reilly pops in a new cassette and the tempo speeds up. And suddenly I realize he's laying down the beat for my rap. The one we created together.

Reilly leans into the microphone. "Listen up, everyone. Jeannie Holtz is going to rap for us. Jeannie, get on up here."

Oh, my God. Everyone is looking at me. I can hear snickering. I'm just sitting there, staring at my feet, trying to will myself to disappear. Someone starts to clap. *"Jean-nie! Jean-nie!"* Soon all the people in the gym are stamping their feet and chanting my name.

Someone grabs my hand and pulls me up. The crowd shoves me onto the stage. I want to die. Just curl up in a corner and die. Then I spot Rory and Mike at the front of the crowd.

"Shake it, Johnny, shake it!" Mike taunts. "Come on, dyke. Show us what you've got."

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That's when it happens. It's like a bomb going off inside of me, ripping me apart. I open my mouth and words explode into the air.

"Am I a girl, a boy, a lesbo. a fag?" I shout. "I don't want a label, I don't need your tag."

I'm glaring at Mike now, spitting out the words. "I'm a person, a human. I need room and a little respect, To grow and connect, Inspect, reject. Find my place in this world, Look for love, try sex."

Everyone is staring at me, stunned-the kids, the teachers, the parent chaperones. But I barely notice. I'm thinking about my mother, my father, Reilly, Rory and Mike. All the confusion, the rejection, the mistakes, the longing, the pain.

I grab the front of my dress and pull as hard as I can. I feel the seams give way. I pull again and the material falls off me, revealing my bike shorts and undershirt. I take off my shoes and throw them into the crowd.

The music is changing now. This is the spot where Reilly wanted me to sing the chorus.

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"I'm a freak," I sing in a low, soulful voice. It's a mournful lament. Then my voice rises. "I'm a freak, a freak, a freak!" It's a proclamation now, a joyful refrain. I jump up on the amplifier and spit out the next lines.

"You want to trash me, smash me, Dis me and bash me.

Still I lower my head and I let you catch me.

Is it something in me,

That makes me freeze?

A fear of talking back,

Of showing feelings, I'm reeling,

I want to shout it to the ceiling:

I won't bow down, you won't catch me kneeling."

"I'm a freak!" I moan, so alone, so sad. "I'm a freak!" I shriek, angry, violent. "I'm a freak, a freak, a freak!" I cry, so joyous, so complete.

And then it's over and there's silence, just silence until someone decides to clap. Soon everyone is applauding, cheering. And I'm standing there in

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my bike shorts and undershirt, barefoot, the shredded dress at my feet, suddenly just me again- only different. Because for the first time in years, in centuries, in eons, I didn't stuff my emotions down inside of me. I was standing on the roof naked, screaming my lungs out, and it felt good.

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